



Essential Wisdom for Continuing on the Way

- 1) Recognize that as you complete the Essentials of Engaged Contemplation course, the invitation to growth and transformation in God continues. Your personal healing, growth, and transformation is contributing to the healing and transformation of the world.
- 2) The CAC and its programs can support and facilitate that change, so you can deepen your engagement in what is yours to do at home. We are here to companion you in *your and our ordinariness*. We are not the answer, but we are fellow pilgrims with you in seeking the questions. **The CAC is not here to solve your problems nearly as much as to reveal your problems to you.** Hopefully, what is revealed will produce a radical humility and patience with yourself and others, especially as you continue to stretch and grow.
- 3) Many of you are, in your own way, “doers,” problem solvers, or change agents. The way of engaged contemplation that you are living into invites you to focus on fully integrating action *with* contemplation. This full integration will come in time, and is not achieved by thinking about integrating them or by trying to do so, but will come through prayer and meditation, through processing and sitting in discomfort and unknowing, and through discernment.
- 4) Many of your habitual inner patterns will likely persist throughout your lifetime. You must learn to compassionately and calmly observe these patterns, and recognize, weep, and laugh over your long-practiced responses, which are now deep and unquestioned habits. Until you *unveil and take ownership* of your own inner thoughts and responses, outer behavioral changes will not last long, and are often not signs of transformation. Only some form of the “prayer of quiet” seems capable of opening and touching your unconscious, where most of your hurts and motives lie hidden.
- 5) As you continue your regular contemplative practice, from time to time you may feel a sense of emptiness, powerlessness, or lack, and you will *not* know what to do with it! You will possibly feel anxiety, restlessness, loneliness, boredom, negativity, aimless irritation, etc. Feeling poor, you will try and want to become “rich.” Know that your usual coping devices are being taken from you by contemplative practice. You will, in time, become much more “undefended,” and this is scary and unfamiliar to the ego. Harsh inner judgments are almost always a way of taking control during times of inner powerlessness and humiliation.
- 6) An underlying worldview informing the Essentials of Engaged Contemplation is a “spirituality of imperfection” that invites us to be patient and nonviolent with ourselves and others. As the Essentials course comes to a close, we ask you to continue to more deeply practice patience with yourself and others.
- 7) Practicing the above principles will facilitate your spiritual transformation where you live more and more from your authentic self in God. The yeast of your self-in-God will begin to leaven the whole dough—first your own, and then that of the people, causes, and groups in your life. And you can begin free, discerned, and compassionate *action*.

These Essential Wisdom principles are adapted from *The Starter Kit of Wisdom* written by Richard Rohr with input from James Finley and Cynthia Bourgeault. *Essential Wisdom for Continuing on the Way* is a set of guiding principles that will assist you in deepening your inner attitude of faithfulness toward what you are being called in and through the Living School. We encourage you to read this every few days, and to reflect on it as you continue to live the teachings forward.

